

5 basic steps for breaking down most commercial VO copy

Step 1: Look at the last line *first*. (disclaimers don't count) Often the last line informs you of the tone of the spot. Also, look to see if the last line ties in with the first line or ties the copy points together?

Step 2: Set apart the first line. Remember to take your time setting it up. The first line is the most important line you will read - you must show right away with your inflection and attitude that you understand the concept.

Step 3: Reformat the copy to create a natural conversational flow, if necessary. Often you are asked to make copy sound conversational, even though it may not be written that way. To achieve this, you may need to remove ellipses, change some periods to commas and group some lines together or add contractions or parentheses to make it sound more natural and conversational to you. **Also, notice any words or phrases that repeat.** This will inform the rhythm and flow of your read.

Step 4: Look for transitions. Most commercials present a problem, then offer a solution. Often the tone subtly shifts at the transition point. Other spots are long anthem spots that you can usually break down into 3 parts. Pay attention to these transitions and how the attitude and pace might slightly shift.

Step 5: Paraphrase the main point of the copy in 1 sentence. Know exactly what the product/service offers and **how it can help your listener.**